Welcome to the Okafor Lab

Your first week: what to do, in what order, and who to meet

Department of Molecular and Cell Biology, Westbrook University · Keller Hall, rooms 412–418
Written by Prof. Adaeze Okafor · Last updated 18 August 2026

Dear new lab member,

Welcome! Whether you are joining us as a graduate student, a postdoc, an undergraduate researcher or a rotation student, I am very glad you are here.

Our lab studies protein quality control: how mammalian cells recognise misfolded membrane proteins and decide whether to refold them or send them for degradation. We work at several scales. We express and purify proteins and study them biochemically; we grow human cell lines at Biosafety Level 2 (BSL-2); a small part of our work uses mouse tissue collected under the lab's approved animal protocol; and we prepare cryo-EM samples at the Westbrook Cryo-EM Facility in the Sato Center.

Your first week is mostly about getting set up *safely*. Please do not start experiments at the bench until you have completed the trainings below, in the order given. This is not bureaucracy. It is how we keep each other safe, and it is why Marisol and Tomasz will ask to see your certificates. Everyone in this lab was new once, and everyone is happy to answer questions. Asking early is always better than guessing.

Three things I care about more than anything else:

1. **Safety first.** If you are unsure whether something is safe, stop and ask Tomasz Brenner (our Lab Safety Officer) or me. Nobody will ever be criticised for stopping.
2. **Honest, well-recorded data.** Negative results and failed experiments go in the notebook too.
3. **Kindness and shared responsibility.** We share instruments, freezers and chores. Leave things better than you found them.

This packet contains: *Welcome and First Week* (this document), *Who Does What* (roles, contacts, chore rota), *Equipment Guide*, *Health and Safety*, *Ordering and Supplies*, *After Hours and Special Materials*, *Writing and Notebook Style*, and *Lab Meeting and Mentoring*. There is also an informal FAQ written by past lab members. It is useful but unofficial; where it disagrees with the other documents, the official documents are correct.

I look forward to meeting you properly at our first 1:1.

Adaeze

Prof. Adaeze Okafor, Keller 418, x4410, aokafor@westbrook.edu

First-week checklist

Day 1

- ☐ **9:00: meet Marisol Vega (Lab Manager) in Keller 414.** She will give you a desk in 417, a drawer key, two lab coats (a white coat for 412/415/416 and a blue coat that stays in the tissue culture room, 413), safety glasses, and a printed copy of this packet. Lab coats are laundered by the lab: leave used coats in the bin in 414 on Fridays.

- ☐ **Westbrook ID card.** If you do not have one, get it at Card Services (Student Union, room 110) and bring the card number to Marisol.
- ☐ **Card access.** Marisol requests business-hours access to Keller 412–418 for you on day 1. It usually takes 2–3 business days; until then a lab member will let you in. *After-hours* access (7 pm–7 am and weekends) is requested separately, only after you complete trainings 1–3 below.
- ☐ **Start training 1** (below).

Accounts to request (Marisol sends the requests; you will receive emails)

- ☐ Westbrook NetID and email (usually created by the department before you arrive).
- ☐ Lab Slack workspace: channels #general, #orders, #equipment, #after-hours, #journal-club.
- ☐ Lab server `okafor-nas` (IT ticket; takes 1–2 business days).
- ☐ Westbrook ELN (electronic lab notebook): Marisol adds you to the "Okafor Lab" group.
- ☐ MCB-Book, the department's instrument booking system (mcbbook.westbrook.edu). You can only book an instrument after its owner marks you as trained.
- ☐ Edit access to the "Okafor Lab Orders 2026" spreadsheet (link pinned in #orders).

Trainings: complete in this order

1. **Westbrook EHS Laboratory Safety Fundamentals** (online, about 2 h). Required before *any* bench work.
2. **Hazardous Chemical Waste Management** (online, about 45 min).
3. **Lab-specific safety orientation with Tomasz Brenner** (in person, 1 h; message Tomasz on Slack to schedule it in your first week). Covers eyewash and shower locations, spill kits, waste stations, the fume hood and emergency procedures. After this you may do *supervised* bench work in 412.
4. **Biosafety and BSL-2 Practices** (online module plus a 1-hour in-person practical at EHS, offered Wednesdays at 2 pm; register on the EHS website).
5. **Bloodborne Pathogens** (online, about 1 h; renewed every year). Required because we work with human cell lines.
6. **Tissue culture room orientation and supervised first session with Mei-Ling Zhou** (TC room owner). Only after trainings 1–5. Mei-Ling signs your TC sign-off sheet and Tomasz countersigns it. You may not work in 413 unsupervised until both have signed.
7. **Cryogen Safety** (online, 30 min), then hands-on liquid nitrogen training with Tomasz. Required before you handle liquid nitrogen or dry ice.

Instrument trainings come after these, with each instrument's owner (see the *Equipment Guide*). **Animal work:** only if you are going to be added to the lab's animal protocol. Talk to me first; rotation students do not do animal work.

Save every training certificate as a PDF in `okafor-nas/admin/training/<yourname>/`.

Who to meet in your first week

- Marisol Vega (Lab Manager): day 1.
- Tomasz Brenner (Senior Postdoc and Lab Safety Officer): safety orientation.
- Your day-to-day mentor. Every new member has one (a postdoc or senior graduate student); rotation students are assigned a rotation mentor before they arrive.
- The owners of the instruments you expect to use (listed in *Who Does What*).
- Me: a 30-minute 1:1 in your first week. Marisol will put it in both our calendars.

Meetings

- **Lab meeting:** every Thursday, 10:00–11:30, Keller 402 (seminar room). Research updates and journal club alternate weekly. Details and the journal club rota are in *Lab Meeting and Mentoring*.
- **Subgroup meetings** (Keller 418A): Protein subgroup, Mondays 14:00; Cell biology subgroup, Wednesdays 11:00. Attend the one that matches your project, or both if your project spans them.

What we expect of each other

- **Core hours.** Be in the lab, or reachable, 10:00–16:00 on weekdays. Outside core hours your schedule is flexible, within the after-hours safety rules.
- **Slack.** Check it on working days and reply within one working day.
- **Notebook.** Record every experiment in the ELN on the day you do it (see *Writing and Notebook Style*).
- **Shared spaces.** Clean your bench at the end of each day, return shared reagents to where you found them, and if you finish a shared stock solution, make the next bottle.
- **Chores.** Everyone, including undergraduates and rotation students, joins the chore rota from their second week.
- **Ask.** There are no silly questions about safety, equipment or where things are.